

AP English Language & Composition: The Complete Exam Guide

The reading and writing multiple choice explained, the synthesis, rhetorical analysis and argument essays, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3:15**

hours total,
including reading time

45+3

multiple-choice +
essays

55%

of your score comes
from the 3 essays

74–75%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section on reading and revising nonfiction with three essays. The essays count for more than half your score.

45%

Section I • Multiple choice • 45 questions

55%

Section II • Free response • 3 essays

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Multiple choice	45% of score about 1 hour 45 questions	23–25 reading questions on nonfiction passages, and 20–22 writing questions where you revise and evaluate drafts.
II • Free response	55% of score 2 hr 15 min (incl. 15-min reading) 3 essays	Synthesis: argue using at least 3 of 6 sources • Rhetorical analysis: explain how a writer's choices achieve a purpose • Argument: defend a position with your own evidence.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

EACH ESSAY IS SCORED 0–6

Thesis, evidence and sophistication

Each essay earns up to **1 point for thesis**, **4 for evidence and commentary**, and **1 for sophistication**. Commentary, explaining *how* evidence supports your claim, is where most points are won or lost.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

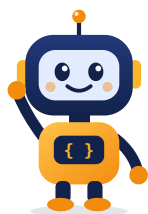
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: AP Lang is about **rhetoric**: how writers persuade. In every text you read, ask who is speaking, to whom, why, and how.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

About 45 questions in roughly an hour. Reading questions ask how a writer builds an argument; writing questions ask how to improve a draft.

45

questions in reading and writing sets

~1:20

minutes per question on average

45%

of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are split

Number of questions of each type. Bars show minimum to maximum.

Reading

Nonfiction passages

23–25 Q

Writing

Revising drafts

20–22 Q

0%

10%

20%

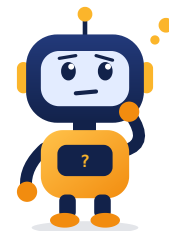
30%

What this means for your study time: Nearly half the multiple choice is about revising writing: choosing the best evidence, transitions and sentence placement. Practice these like a writer, not just a reader.

Strategies that work on this section

- **Read for the argument:** identify the writer's claim and purpose in the first pass.
- **For revision questions,** read the sentences before and after. The best choice fits the paragraph's purpose.
- **Pay attention to the question's goal:** "to provide evidence", "to qualify the claim", "to transition".
- **Eliminate choices that are true but irrelevant** to the specific purpose asked.
- **Know rhetorical terms:** concession, rebuttal, anecdote, appeal, juxtaposition.
- **Never leave a blank.** Guess, flag and move on.

In revision questions, the right answer does **exactly** what the question says the writer wants.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The skills, in plain English

The course is organized into 9 units, but they all build four skills.

SKILL

1

Rhetorical situation

Who is writing, to whom, about what, and why.

Be ready to: identify the writer's purpose, audience, exigence (what prompted the writing) and context, and explain how they shape the writer's choices.

SKILL

2

Claims & evidence

What the writer argues and how it is supported.

Be ready to: identify and evaluate claims; judge whether evidence is relevant and sufficient; integrate sources into your own writing.

SKILL

3

Reasoning & organization

How an argument is put together.

Be ready to: explain lines of reasoning; use transitions; organize paragraphs; recognize methods of development such as comparison, cause and effect, and definition.

SKILL

4

Style

How word choice and syntax create effects.

Be ready to: analyze diction, syntax, tone and figurative language; explain how stylistic choices affect the audience; control your own style for effect.

Reading list? AP Lang has no required texts. Read a wide mix of nonfiction (op-eds, speeches, essays and long-form journalism) and notice how each writer persuades.

SECTION II

04 The 3 essays

2 hours 15 minutes for three essays, including a 15-minute reading period for the synthesis sources. Each essay is scored out of 6.

Synthesis • 6 pts

Rhetorical analysis • 6 pts

Argument • 6 pts

Each essay: thesis (1) + evidence & commentary (4) + sophistication (1)

Q1

Synthesis

~55 min with reading time

Read 6 sources on an issue, then write an argument that uses at least **3** of them as evidence for your own position.

Your argument leads; sources support it. Don't summarize them in order.

Q2

Rhetorical analysis

~40 minutes

Read a nonfiction passage and explain how the writer's choices help achieve a purpose for an audience.

Analyze choices (what the writer does) and effects (why it works), not devices in isolation.

Q3

Argument

~40 minutes

Take a position on an open-ended claim and support it with your own evidence: history, current events, reading or experience.

Specific, well-explained evidence beats many vague examples.

♦ A time plan for the 135 minutes

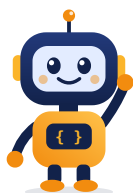
Read sources
15 min

Synthesis
40 min

Rhetorical
40 min

Argument
40 min

Suggested timing. You may work on the essays in any order once the reading period ends.



The **sophistication** point rewards nuance: acknowledge complexity, tensions or limits of your own argument.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05 Anatomy of a strong paragraph

Commentary earns most of the points. Here is a short practice passage and a strong rhetorical-analysis paragraph.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice passage (original, for analysis): *A columnist writes to fellow residents in a local newspaper.* (1) Every September, our town debates whether to replace the old library with a modern "learning hub." (2) The proposal promises charging stations, soundproof pods and a café. (3) Yet in all the glossy brochures, one word is strangely absent: books. (4) Supporters insist that the hub would draw young people back downtown, and perhaps it would. (5) But a library is not merely a building that people visit; it is a promise that knowledge belongs to everyone, regardless of whether they can pay for coffee. (6) Before we trade that promise for a lounge, we should ask what, exactly, we hope our children will find inside.

Sample analysis paragraph

- ① The columnist first **concedes** that the hub "would draw young people back downtown, and perhaps it would," which builds credibility with readers who support the proposal.
- ② She then pivots with "But" to **redefine** a library as "a promise that knowledge belongs to everyone."
- ③ By contrasting this promise with the image of a "lounge" where people "pay for coffee," she suggests the new plan quietly excludes residents who cannot afford to spend.
- ④ This shift from concession to moral definition moves readers from a practical debate to a question of fairness, preparing them to accept her final challenge about "what... our children will find inside."

- ① **Name the choice** (concession) and quote it briefly.
- ② **Track the move** in the argument, not just the device.
- ③ **Explain the effect** on this audience.
- ④ **Link back to purpose:** how the choice serves her argument.

◆ Five habits for every essay

1

Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.

2

Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.

3

Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.

4

Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.

5

Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just list the **devices**!
(Please don't.)



01 Device hunting

"The author uses imagery" earns nothing alone. Explain how a choice serves the writer's purpose.

02 Summary instead of analysis

Retelling what the writer says is not analysis. Focus on how and why they say it.

03 Thesis restates the prompt

A thesis must make a defensible claim with a line of reasoning, not repeat the question.

04 Source summary in synthesis

Use sources as evidence for your argument; don't walk through them one by one.

05 Too few sources

The synthesis essay needs at least 3 sources to reach the top evidence scores.

06 Vague evidence in argument

"Many people believe..." is weak. Use specific examples and explain them.

07 No commentary

After every piece of evidence, explain how it supports your claim.

08 Ignoring the audience

Rhetorical analysis is about the writer's audience. Mention who they are and why choices fit them.

09 Writing about ethos, pathos, logos only

The appeals are a start, not an analysis. Name specific choices.

10 Running out of time

Watch the clock; three completed essays score better than two polished ones.

Quick self-check: for the passage on the previous page, can you state the writer's purpose and audience in one sentence? (To persuade fellow residents to question replacing the library, framing it as a matter of equal access.)

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Write one timed essay every two weeks and read nonfiction every day.



Sep – Oct Rhetoric basics	Rhetorical situation & claims Read op-eds and speeches daily. Write short paragraphs analyzing one choice and its effect.
Nov – Dec Analysis	Rhetorical analysis essay Timed rhetorical analysis every two weeks. Practice commentary until it is longer than your quotes.
Jan – Feb Argument	Argument essay Build a bank of specific evidence from history, current events and reading. Write timed argument essays.
Mar – Apr Synthesis + MCQ	Synthesis and revision questions all three Synthesis essays with 6 sources, plus reading and writing multiple-choice sets.
Early May Sharpen	Full timed sections All three essays in one sitting. Review the rubric and traps list.
Exam day May	AP Lang exam • Bluebook Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one multiple-choice set and one timed essay	Name your weakest essay type
3 weeks out	Two timed essays of your weakest type	Commentary after every quote
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour-15-minute practice exam	Finish all three essays
Final week	Light review: thesis templates, rubric, evidence bank	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Questions 1–5 use the passage below. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 READING • RHETORICAL SITUATION

A columnist writes to fellow residents in a local newspaper.

(1) Every September, our town debates whether to replace the old library with a modern "learning hub." (2) The proposal promises charging stations, soundproof pods and a café. (3) Yet in all the glossy brochures, one word is strangely absent: books. (4) Supporters insist that the hub would draw young people back downtown, and perhaps it would. (5) But a library is not merely a building that people visit; it is a promise that knowledge belongs to everyone, regardless of whether they can pay for coffee. (6) Before we trade that promise for a lounge, we should ask what, exactly, we hope our children will find inside.

Original passage written by ACT SAT GO for practice

In sentence 4, the writer's concession ("and perhaps it would") primarily serves to:

- A undermine the writer's own argument
- B introduce statistical evidence
- C shift the topic from libraries to cafés
- D show fairness toward the proposal's supporters before challenging them

2 READING • CLAIMS

Which sentence states the writer's central claim most directly?

- A Sentence 2
- B Sentence 3
- C Sentence 5
- D Sentence 6

3 READING • STYLE

In sentence 3, the phrase "strangely absent" mainly creates a tone of:

- A pointed skepticism
- B enthusiastic support
- C neutral reporting
- D angry hostility

4 READING • REASONING

The contrast between a "promise" and a "lounge" in sentences 5–6 mainly suggests that the proposal:

- A is too expensive to build
- B values comfort over the library's public purpose
- C will attract too few visitors
- D should include more charging stations

5 WRITING • REVISION

The writer wants to add evidence after sentence 4 to strengthen the concession. Which is most effective?

- A A note that the library was built in 1924
- B A description of the café's menu
- C Survey data showing that 62% of teenagers would visit a new hub weekly
- D A quotation praising the town's parks

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 WRITING • TRANSITIONS

A draft reads: "Recycling programs reduce landfill waste. ___, many towns have cut them to save money." Which transition is best?

- A Therefore
- B Nevertheless
- C Similarly
- D For example

7 WRITING • EVIDENCE

A writer argues that later school start times improve student health. Which evidence would be **most** persuasive to school administrators?

- A A student's personal story about feeling tired
- B A quotation from a famous novelist about sleep
- C A list of countries with different school hours
- D A multi-district study linking later start times to fewer absences and better grades

8 WRITING • CONCISION

Which revision of "In my personal opinion, I think that the policy is basically unfair" is clearest and most concise?

- A The policy is unfair.
- B In my opinion, I personally think the policy is unfair.
- C I think, in my opinion, that it is unfair basically.
- D Basically, the policy is, in my view, kind of unfair.

9 READING • PURPOSE

A speech to a graduating class opens with a joke about the speaker's own failed first job. The joke most likely aims to:

- A establish the speaker's authority through credentials
- B distract from the main message
- C build rapport and make a later lesson about failure feel personal
- D present statistical evidence

10 WRITING • ORGANIZATION

A paragraph argues that bike lanes help local businesses. Where should the sentence "Of course, some drivers worry about losing parking" go?

- A Just before the writer responds to that concern
- B At the very start of the essay
- C In the conclusion only
- D It should be deleted because it weakens the argument

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D	The concession acknowledges supporters' point fairly, building credibility, before "But" introduces the writer's challenge.
2	C • Sentence 5	Sentence 5 defines the library as a promise of equal access to knowledge, the core of the argument. Sentence 6 is a call to reflect.
3	A	"Strangely absent" is understated irony: it signals doubt about the proposal without open anger.
4	B	The contrast implies the hub swaps a public mission (equal access) for comfort and spending.
5	C	Data on teenagers' interest directly supports the concession that the hub "would draw young people," making the concession credible.
6	B • Nevertheless	The second sentence contrasts with the first: programs work, yet towns cut them. "Nevertheless" signals that contrast.
7	D	Administrators respond to broad, measurable outcomes. A multi-district study is more persuasive than one anecdote.
8	A	Removing redundant phrases ("in my personal opinion, I think", "basically") leaves a direct claim.
9	C	Self-deprecating humor builds rapport (ethos) and sets up a lesson about resilience.
10	A	A counterargument works best placed right before the writer's response, so the rebuttal follows immediately.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Practice identifying the purpose and audience of everything you read.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 74–75% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP English Language and Composition, and about 13–15% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

74–75%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

13–15%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **~1 hr** for multiple choice; **15 min** reading, then about **40 min** per essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Have a **bank of specific examples** ready for the argument essay
- ☐ Practice typing a full essay in 40 minutes before exam day

In the essays: open with a defensible thesis that sets out your line of reasoning, follow every piece of evidence with commentary, use at least three sources in the synthesis essay, and show nuance for the sophistication point.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

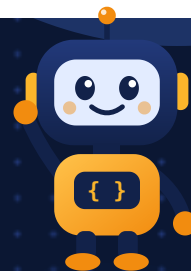
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